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ACADEMIC WRITING

ANSWER STRUCTURES

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VIDEO 1

Session Outcomes

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By the end of this session you should be able to:

- Understand what learning outcomes are and what they mean when writing assignments

Learning Outcomes and how they impact assignments

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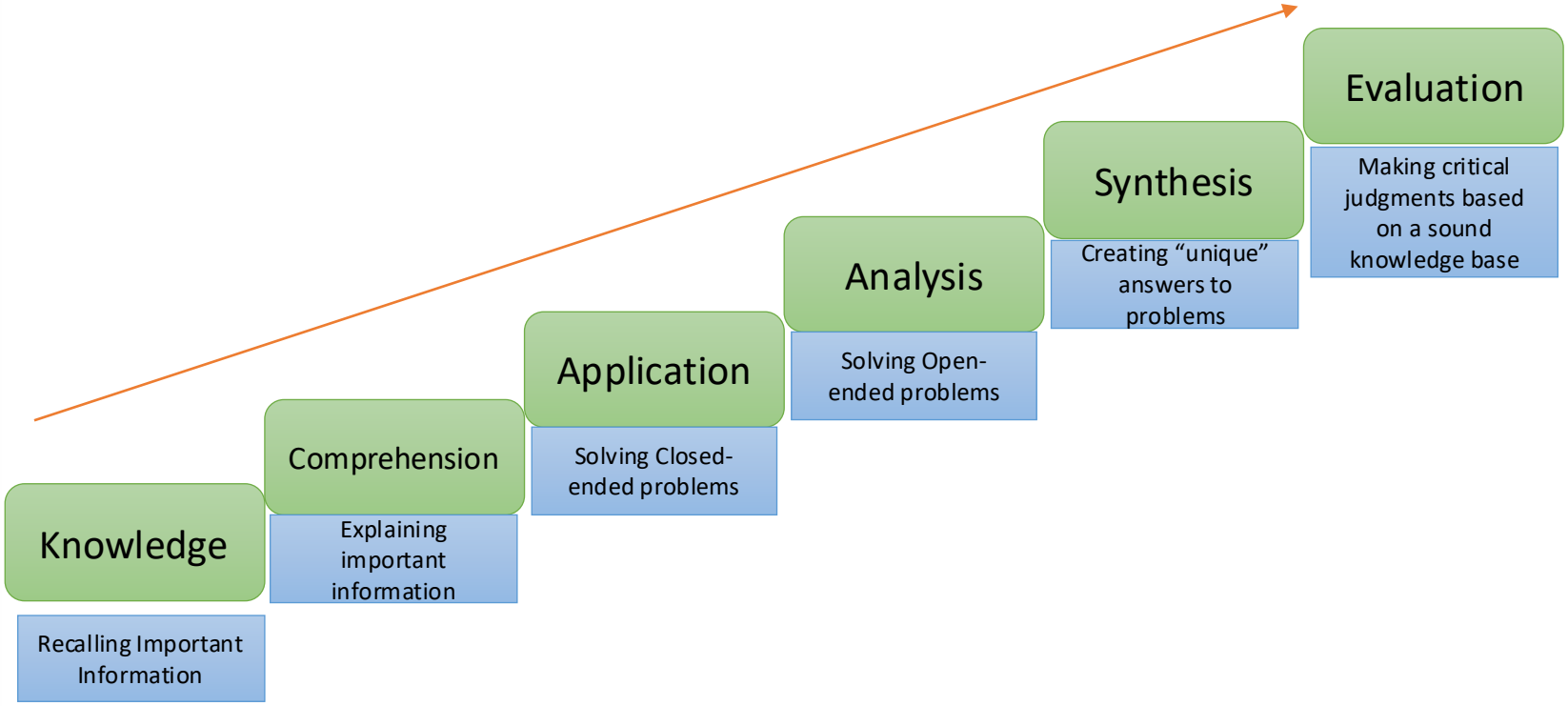
- Learning outcomes are the specific intentions of a programme/module stated in measurable terms
- They specify what you will be able to do at the end of the module
- Understanding what different words in Learning Outcomes mean is vital to know what is expected



Learning Outcomes and how they impact assignments

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Knowledge

Recalling important information

- Define
- List
- Name
- Recall
- Recognise
- Record
- Relate
- Repeat
- Reproduce
- Select
- State
- Underline
- Write

Comprehension

Explaining important information

- Contrast
- Describe
- Discuss
- Explain
- Express
- Formulate
- Identify
- Illustrate
- Locate
- Paraphrase
- Recognise
- Report
- Represent
- Restate
- Review
- Summarise
- Tell
- Translate

Application

Solving closed-ended problems

- Apply
- Assess
- Compute
- Construct
- Demonstrate
- Dramatise
- Employ
- Find
- Illustrate
- Interpret
- Operate
- Practice
- Predict
- Schedule
- Select
- Show
- Sketch
- Solve
- Use

Analysis

Solving open-ended problems

- Analyse
- Appraise
- Break down
- Calculate
- Categorise
- Classify
- Compare
- Contrast
- Criticise
- Debate
- Diagram
- Differentiate
- Distinguish
- Examine
- Experiment
- Inspect
- Question
- Relate
- Select
- Separate
- Solve
- Test

Synthesis

Creating 'unique' answers to problems

- Argue
- Arrange
- Assemble
- Collect
- Compose
- Conclude
- Construct
- Create
- Design
- Formulate
- Generalise
- Manage
- Organise
- Plan
- Prècis
- Prepare
- Propose
- Relate
- Set Up
- Summarise

Evaluation

Making critical judgments based on a sound knowledge base

- Appraise
- Assess
- Avoid
- Compare
- Conclude
- Criticise
- Estimate
- Evaluate
- Judge
- Rate
- Recognise
- Revise
- Select
- Support

Learning Outcomes are created based on Bloom's Taxonomy

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VIDEO 2

Session Outcomes

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By the end of this session you should be able to:

- Understand different types of structures and formats used in academic assignments

Types of Academic Writing

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You will have to submit a number of assignments and finally your research report.

These assessments may have to be submitted in a variety of formats:

- Report
- Reflective paper
- Presentation
- Essay

Reports

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Typical Order of a report

- Title Page
- Contents
- Executive Summary
- Introduction
- Body
- Conclusion
- Recommendations
- Reflection (if required)
- References
- Appendices

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Writing Introductions

Introductions to assignments tend to be relatively short.

They must not share content, but rather, explain briefly to the reader what they will find in the body of the assignment.

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Writing Conclusions

Conclusions are shorter sections of academic texts which usually serve two functions.

- To summarise and bring together the main areas covered in the writing, which might be called ‘looking back’
- To give a final comment or judgement on this.

Conclusions should

- Draw everything together
- Summarise the key takeaways
- Do not introduce new material
- Discuss what you have failed to do – answers not clear, space limited

Report Guidelines

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- Ensure consistency *across* the document.
- Despite being structured in sections, a report should:
  - *look* like a single coherent document
  - have a single visual style [e.g. font, line-spacing, underlining of headings]
  - have justified margins
  - *read* like a single coherent document
  - sections should be linked (bridging)
  - writing style should be consistent

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Reflection

- It’s all about looking back, critically, at your learning experience.

Reflective Papers

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Reflective Writing

- Looks back at learning experiences
- Analyses, explores and explains what happened and why
- Involves constructively criticising your learning experience
- Requires evidence to support what you are saying (e.g. referring to particular instances, events, activities, etc.)
- Uses academic language
  - BUT **unlike in other types of academic writing, you can use personal language such as 'I' and 'we' to talk about observations, emotions and feelings**

Presentations

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- Presentations need to be very straightforward and logical – most often they are “visual aids” to support the actual “verbal” presentation.
- Avoid complex structures
- Be mindful when structuring your slide deck.
- Focus on the need to explain and discuss your work clearly.

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Presentations

An ideal structure for a presentation includes:

- a welcoming and informative introduction
- a coherent series of main points presented in a logical sequence
- a lucid and purposeful conclusion

Presentations often require speaker notes when **not** verbally presented

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Academic Essays

- A structured, evidence-based, and argumentative piece of writing
- Key features include
  - formal tone
  - logical structure
  - Use of references

Academic Essays

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A model essay structure will be

- Introduction
  - Give a brief outline of what is included, and in which order
- Argument/Main Body
  - Contains the points outlined in your introduction, divided into paragraphs:
    - *Paragraph 1*
      Covers the first thing you said you would address
    - *Paragraph 2*
      Covers the second thing you said you would address
- Conclusion
  - Draw everything together
  - State your general conclusions
  - Do not introduce new material

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VIDEO 3

Session Outcomes

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By the end of this session you should be able to:

- Understand the dynamics of paragraphs in academic assessments
- Get familiar with paragraph writing skills

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Writing paragraphs

A paragraph is a unit of ideas; there should only be ONE new idea in each paragraph – usually.

- Good paragraphs have
  - Unity
  - Coherence

- Paragraphs
  - are the building blocks of writing
  - aid the reader by breaking up the text into units
  - provide logical breaks in subject matter
  - develop ideas

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A well-written paragraph

Key features

- It contains a topic sentence (sets up expectations for reader)
- Only ONE idea is developed (unity)
- The sentences follow each other in a logical sequence (coherence)
- Develop the topic sentence by giving evidence, supporting facts, and examples (support)
- Further descriptions can be included as foot notes (optional)

Length

- There is no ‘right’ length
- Paragraphs in academic documents tend to be relatively long
- A document consisting of very short paragraphs can read like a list
- But paragraphs that are too long are hard to read; don’t have one paragraph for the entire page!!

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Typical paragraph structure

- There are, of course, no golden rules
- A concluding sentence is <u>usually not needed</u>, unless a paragraph is free-standing
- Ultimately structure should follow content

- Topic sentence
- Body
  - Supporting sentence 1
  - Supporting sentence 2
  - Supporting sentence 3
  - Etc.
- Concluding sentence (optional)

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Example Paragraph A

Topic sentence

Gold, a precious metal, is prized for two important characteristics. First of all, gold has a lustrous beauty that is resistant to corrosion. Therefore it is suitable for jewelry, coins, and ornamental purposes. Gold never needs to be polished and will remain beautiful forever. For example, a Macedonian coin remains as untarnished today as the day it was made twenty-three centuries ago. Another important characteristic of gold is its usefulness to industry and science. For many years, it has been used in hundreds of industrial applications. The most recent use of gold is in astronauts' suits. Astronauts wear gold plated heat shields for protection outside the spaceship. In conclusion, gold is treasured not only for its beauty, but also its utility.

Concluding Sentence

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Example Paragraph B

Albert Einstein, one of the world's geniuses, failed his university entrance examinations on his first attempt. William Faulkner, one of America's noted writers, never finished college because he could not pass his English courses. Sir Winston Churchill, who is considered one of the masters of the English language, had to have special tutoring in English during elementary school. These few examples show that failure in school does not always predict failure in life.

Topic sentence

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Transition between Paragraphs

- Paragraphs need to be linked together with connective devices
- There are two key approaches:
  - Take an idea from the end of one paragraph and use it to start the next
  - Use transition words/phrases to signal the direction your writing is taking

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An Example of the first approach

Unlike many countries in Europe, multiple voting shares do not exist in Thailand. Thai law prohibits the issuance of such shares. Therefore, when we identify who owns and controls the sample firms, we focus only on three control mechanisms, namely, direct, pyramidal, and cross-shareholdings.

The first form of control mechanism, “Direct ownership”, means a shareholder who owns shares under his own name or via a private company owned by him. “Indirect ownership” is when a company is owned via other public firms or a chain of public firms. …

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Transition words/ phrases

- Certain words are used to link ideas together and,
- Signpost to the reader the direction of your line of reasoning is about to take such as:
  - Position in sequence
  - Cause/effect
  - Introducing examples
  - Introducing an alternative

Time/Sequence	first(ly), second(ly), next, finally
Introduce an additional Idea	in addition, moreover, furthermore
Introduce an example	for example, for instance
Comparison or contrast	similarly, on the other hand, in contrast, while
Cause/ effect	consequently, therefore, because, hence, thus